

THE LITERAL GENIE LESSON • LESSON 1 OF 6

How to Talk to AI



A 45-minute prompt-writing lesson. The hook: AI is a literal genie — it grants exactly what your words ask for, not what your brain meant. Students learn the two human jobs in every AI task: start it well (the prompt) and end it well (the check).

AT A GLANCE

TIME	MATERIALS	TECH NEEDED	PREP
45 min	Cursed Wish Repair Shop worksheet (1 per student)	Optional — works fully unplugged	Print worksheets. That's it.

OBJECTIVES

- Students can explain why the same AI gives different quality answers to different prompts.
- Students can apply the **P.R.O. framework** (Purpose, Requirements, Output) to write a clear prompt.
- Students can evaluate an AI response for accuracy and identify when to double-check it.

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

ISTE 1.5.c

ISTE 1.3.b

CCSS ELA W.6.4

Full standards text in the Teacher Guide.

✦ WARM-UP — THE WORST GENIE EVER (8 MIN)

Announce that you are a genie, and you grant wishes *exactly as worded*. Take 3–4 wishes from the class and ruin every one, cheerfully:

"I wish I was rich." → "Done. Your name is now Rich."

"I wish for a million dollars." → "Granted — one million dollars, in play money."

"I wish school was over." → "Granted. The school building is now over... there."

Then ask: **whose fault was that — the genie's, or the wish?**

Bridge: "AI works like that genie. It doesn't know what you meant — it only knows what you SAID. Every AI job goes human, AI, human: you start it with the wish, the genie does the middle, and you check what comes back. Today you get good at both human parts."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION — CLAUSES OF A GENIE-PROOF WISH (10 MIN)

Lawyers make contracts genie-proof with clauses. Strong prompts have three — write **P.R.O.** on the board:

P — Purpose. What you want + who it's for. "*Explain photosynthesis to a 6th grader*" beats "*explain photosynthesis.*"

R — Requirements. The fine print: length, tone, format, include/avoid. This is what stops the genie from twisting your wish.

O — Output. What should the granted wish look like? A list? A paragraph? A table? A plan?

Model it live (on the board or with a projected AI tool):

CURSED WISH	GENIE-PROOF P.R.O. PROMPT
"help with my history essay"	"I'm writing a 5-paragraph essay for 7th grade history on why the printing press mattered. Give me 3 possible thesis statements and 2 pieces of evidence for each, as a bullet list. Don't write the essay for me."

Say it plainly: "See the last clause — *don't write the essay for me*. AI is your editor, not your ghostwriter. It gives a second opinion on YOUR work; it doesn't hand in work with your name on it."

ACTIVITY — CURSED WISH REPAIR SHOP (22 MIN)

- Repair (9 min):** Solo, students fix three kids' cursed wishes on the worksheet — Amara, Mateo, and Yuki — using all three P.R.O. clauses.
- Break it (8 min):** Pairs swap sheets and play the Worst Genie Ever: misread each repaired wish as literally as possible, then score it with the Genie-Proof Checklist. Twistable = needs more fine print.
- Showcase (5 min):** 2–3 students read a "cursed → genie-proof" before-and-after. With devices: run the best one live and critique what comes back.

EXIT TICKET (5 MIN)

Teach the trickster rule first (1 min): "Genies are tricksters — AI can grant your wish with made-up facts, and sound sure. Anything checkable — a name, a date, a number — gets checked somewhere real before you use it." Then, bottom of worksheet: students write one genie-proof prompt for another class this week, and name **one thing they'd double-check** before trusting the answer.

DIFFERENTIATION

- Support:** Provide the P.R.O. sentence starters (Teacher Guide, p.2).
- Extension:** Write a wish that CAN'T be genie-proofed in under 50 words — then explain why.
- ELL:** The P.R.O. sentence starters double as language frames; students may draft wishes in their strongest language first, then translate.
- No-device classrooms:** Built in — the teacher and partners ARE the genie.